

Guide 5: The Nisab Explained: How Much Wealth Triggers Zakat?

Good Measure Giving

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REVIEW

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TL;DR (shown at top of page)

Nisab is the minimum wealth that makes zakat obligatory — set by the Prophet ﷺ at 20 gold dinars (85 grams of gold) or 200 silver dirhams (595 grams of silver). The two benchmarks were once roughly equal in value; today gold's nisab is many times higher than silver's, which is why scholars differ on which to use. Our calculators display a live gold-based nisab computed from current spot prices. If your zakatable wealth is above nisab at the start and end of a lunar year, zakat is due at 2.5% (schools differ on mid-year dips).

What nisab is and where the numbers come from

Nisab is the wealth threshold below which no zakat is owed. The logic is dignity in both directions: zakat is taken only from those with genuine surplus, so a person living near subsistence is a candidate to receive zakat, not to pay it.

The thresholds are Prophetic, not derived: 20 dinars of gold or 200 dirhams of silver, which contemporary scholarship most commonly standardizes to 85 grams of pure gold and 595 grams of pure silver (some bodies, including the UK's National Zakat Foundation, use 87.48 and 612.36 grams). Anyone whose zakatable wealth — cash, gold, investments, trade goods — meets either benchmark for a full lunar year owes zakat at 2.5%.

In the Prophet's time the two benchmarks were approximately equal in purchasing power, so it didn't matter which you measured against. Centuries of diverging gold and silver prices broke that equivalence, and that divergence is the source of nearly every modern nisab question.

Gold nisab or silver nisab?

At 2026 prices the gap is dramatic: 85 grams of gold is worth roughly \$13,000, while 595 grams of silver is worth on the order of \$1,000. Whether you owe zakat at all can depend entirely on which benchmark you adopt.

The case for silver: it's the lower threshold, so more people pay zakat and more reaches the poor — many Hanafi authorities and several contemporary zakat bodies prefer it for exactly that reason, and it's the more cautious position for mixed wealth. The case for gold: gold has held its function as the monetary standard far better than silver, whose value collapsed relative to its classical role, making the silver nisab arguably too low to mark 'genuine surplus' today — a person with \$1,000 to their name is not wealthy by any measure.

Both positions are legitimately held. Our calculators use the gold nisab, computed live; if you follow the silver benchmark or your wealth sits between the two, treat our threshold display accordingly and consult your scholar. Whichever you adopt, consistency year to year matters more than the choice itself.

How nisab interacts with the zakat year

Nisab is not a one-time gate but the start of a clock. The day your zakatable wealth first crosses nisab, your personal zakat year (hawl) begins — measured in lunar months, so about 11 days shorter than a solar year. If you're still above nisab on the anniversary, zakat is due on what you hold that day.

Temporary dips during the year are treated differently across schools. The Hanafi position checks only the two endpoints: above nisab at the start and at the anniversary, and zakat is due even if you dipped in between. The majority of other schools hold that falling below nisab breaks the year and the clock restarts when you cross it again. If your balance hovers near the threshold, this is a live question for your scholar.

Nisab is assessed per person, not per household. A married couple each apply nisab to their own wealth — a spouse's gold and a spouse's savings are separate zakat calculations, which surprises many families running combined finances.

What counts toward nisab

Nisab is measured against your total zakatable wealth combined — not asset by asset. Cash and bank balances, gold and silver, stocks, crypto, business inventory and receivables, and saved rental income all pool into one figure; short-term debts you owe subtract from it under the majority view. You don't need \$13,000 in cash alone — \$5,000 in savings plus \$9,000 in gold crosses the gold nisab together.

Non-zakatable assets stay out of the calculation entirely: your home, car, furniture, and the tools or equipment of your trade neither owe zakat nor count toward the threshold. Our zakat calculator pages walk through each asset class — cash, gold and silver, stocks, retirement accounts,

crypto, business assets, and real estate — with the rules and disputes specific to each.

The threshold moves daily because gold moves daily. Our calculator computes nisab live from the current spot price of 85 grams of gold rather than quoting a stale annual figure — a meaningful difference in years when gold moves 20%.

Close to the line?

If your wealth sits near nisab, three practical notes. First, the measurement date is your anniversary, not your best or worst day of the year — compute honestly on that date. Second, remember debts: short-term liabilities reduce your zakatable total and can pull you below the threshold legitimately. Third, if you're just below the gold nisab but well above silver's, you're in the zone where the benchmark choice decides the obligation — a good reason to ask your scholar rather than pick whichever answer is cheaper.

And if you're below nisab entirely: you owe nothing, and the system is working as designed. Sadaqah remains open at any level — the threshold guards the obligation, not generosity.

Callout boxes (highlighted on page)

Live nisab on this site — Our calculator pages display nisab computed from the live gold spot price (85 grams × current USD price per gram), with a conservative fallback if the price feed is unavailable. Scholars differ on using the gold versus silver benchmark — the figure shown is the gold nisab.

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: What is the nisab in dollars right now?

It changes daily with the gold price. The benchmark is fixed — 85 grams of gold — but its dollar value moves; in 2026 it has been in the neighborhood of \$13,000. Our zakat calculator shows the live figure each time you use it.

Q: Why are the gold and silver nisab so different?

They were roughly equal in value when set — 20 gold dinars or 200 silver dirhams. Silver's value has collapsed relative to gold over the centuries, so the silver nisab (595g, roughly \$1,000) now sits far below the gold nisab (85g, roughly \$13,000). That divergence is why scholars differ on which to apply.

Q: Do I combine my cash and gold to reach nisab?

Yes. Zakatable wealth pools into one figure for the nisab test — cash, precious metals, investments, business assets, minus short-term debts. The majority view combines monetary asset classes rather than testing each separately.

Q: My wealth dipped below nisab mid-year. Did my zakat year reset?

Schools differ. The Hanafi view checks only the start and the anniversary — a mid-year dip doesn't break the year. The majority view holds the dip resets the clock until you cross nisab again. If you hover near the line, ask your scholar which position to follow.

Q: Does my spouse's wealth count toward my nisab?

No — nisab and zakat are assessed per person. Each spouse measures their own zakatable wealth against the threshold and pays on their own holdings, even in households with fully merged finances.

Q: Is there a different nisab for crops or livestock?

Yes — agricultural produce and livestock have their own thresholds and rates from the classical sources (and produce is zakated at harvest, not annually). This guide and our calculators cover monetary wealth, which is what applies to most donors today.

Sources & further reading (as shown on page)

Preceded on the page by: "This guide presents broadly held positions in Sunni fiqh and names the schools where they differ. The references below are where we drew them from. None of this is a fatwa."

- **Is the Nisab for Paper Money Based on Silver or Gold? (Fatwa 370380)**, IslamQA.info — [https://islamqa.info/en/answers/370380SMARTPANTS_PRESERVED_112_Favors_the_silver_nisab_for_cash_citing_the_Saudi_Council_of_Senior_Scholars — 'in the best interests of the poor.'](https://islamqa.info/en/answers/370380SMARTPANTS_PRESERVED_112_Favors_the_silver_nisab_for_cash_citing_the_Saudi_Council_of_Senior_Scholars_-_in_the_best_interests_of_the_poor.)
- **Zakat Nisab Today — What is Nisab**, National Zakat Foundation (UK) — [https://nzf.org.uk/nisab/SMARTPANTS_PRESERVED_120_Uses_87.48g_gold / 612.36g silver and recommends the silver nisab for mixed assets as 'safer and more beneficial for the recipients of Zakat.'](https://nzf.org.uk/nisab/SMARTPANTS_PRESERVED_120_Uses_87.48g_gold_612.36g_silver_and_recommends_the_silver_nisab_for_mixed_assets_as_safer_and_more_beneficial_for_the_recipients_of_Zakat.)

- **Shari'ah Standard No. 35: Zakah**, AAOIFI — https://aaoifi.com/ss-35-zakah/?lang=enSMARTPANTS_RESERVED_128 The zakat standard used by Islamic financial institutions.
- **If wealth dips below the nisab during the year (Fatwa 99381)**, IslamQA.info — https://islamqa.info/en/answers/99381SMARTPANTS_RESERVED_136 The majority position: a dip below nisab interrupts the zakat year (Maliki, Hanbali, al-Nawawi).
- **Is it necessary to own Zakatable assets above the Nisab threshold for the entire year?**, National Zakat Foundation (UK) — https://nzf.org.uk/knowledge/is-it-necessary-to-own-zakatable-assets-above-the-nisab-threshold-for-the-entire-year/SMARTPANTS_RESERVED_144 The Hanafi position: only the start and anniversary dates matter, unless wealth falls to zero.
- **Deducting Debt from Your Zakat Calculation**, Joe Bradford — https://joebradford.substack.com/p/deducting-debt-from-your-zakat-calculationSMARTPANTS_RESERVED_152 The school positions on debt deduction, including the relied-upon Shafi'i view that debt does not reduce zakatable wealth.